

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 1: The Spark

The fluorescent lights of the convenience store flickered as Hayami restocked the energy drink cooler, the monotonous beep of the cash register providing a rhythmic backdrop to another unremarkable night shift. February had always been their least favorite month—cold, dark, and uneventful. They were reaching for another case when the pain hit.

It started as a pinprick behind their eyes, then exploded into something that felt like their skull was splitting open from the inside. Hayami stumbled backward, knocking over a display of instant ramen. The world tilted sideways.

Then they saw it.

A translucent blue screen materialized in front of their face, words scrolling across it like something out of a video game:

[SYSTEM INITIALIZATION COMPLETE]

[CONGRATULATIONS! YOU HAVE AWAKENED AS A HUNTER]

[ANALYZING ABILITIES...]

[ANALYSIS COMPLETE]

Hayami blinked hard, shaking their head. The screen didn't disappear. If anything, it became clearer.

[HUNTER PROFILE]

- **Name:** Hayami Amamiya
- **Rank:** E
- **Class:** Mage
- **Level:** 1
- **Title:** None

[ABILITIES DETECTED]

- **Lightning Manipulation (Basic)** - Rank E

That was it. One ability. No skills section. No equipment. Just... lightning manipulation?

"What the hell..." Hayami muttered, waving their hand through the screen. Their fingers passed through it like smoke, but the display remained stubbornly visible.

They looked around the store. The manager was in the back office. No customers at this hour. No one else seemed to see the glowing interface floating in their vision.

Cautiously, Hayami raised their right hand and concentrated on the words "Lightning Manipulation." They weren't sure what they expected—maybe nothing would happen. Maybe this was some kind of stress-induced hallucination from too many late shifts.

A spark crackled between their fingers.

Hayami yelped and jerked their hand back, but the tiny arc of electricity danced across their knuckles, blue-white and very, very real. It didn't hurt. If anything, it felt... natural. Like the electricity was an extension of their own body.

"Okay," they breathed, watching the sparks fade. "Okay. This is happening. This is actually happening."

They'd heard about Hunters, of course. Everyone had. Three years ago, the Gates started appearing—rifts to other dimensions filled with monsters. And with the Gates came the Awakened, people who suddenly developed supernatural abilities and could enter the Gates to fight the creatures inside. Hunters were celebrities now, especially the high-rankers. Their faces were on billboards and energy drink cans.

But Hayami had never imagined they would be one of them.

The blue screen flickered, and new text appeared:

[ALERT: UNAUTHORIZED AWAKENING DETECTED]

[HUNTER ASSOCIATION HAS BEEN NOTIFIED OF YOUR COORDINATES]

[PLEASE REMAIN AT YOUR CURRENT LOCATION]

"Wait, what—"

The convenience store door chimed. Three people in sleek black suits entered, and Hayami knew immediately they weren't here for cigarettes. The woman in front had an ID badge clipped to her lapel—the Hunter Association's distinctive emblem, a shield with a sword and staff crossed behind a gate symbol.

"Hayami Amamiya?" Her voice was professional, clipped. "I'm Agent Tanaka from the Hunter Association's Registration Bureau. You've just Awakened, correct?"

Hayami's mouth went dry. "I... how did you—"

"The System automatically alerts us to all new Awakenings." Agent Tanaka's expression softened slightly.

"Don't worry. This is standard procedure. We need you to come with us for registration and ability assessment. It's required by law."

"Right now? I'm still on shift—"

"We've already contacted your employer. This takes priority." One of the other agents, a tall man with silver hair, stepped forward with a tablet. "The sooner we complete registration, the sooner you can go home. Or we can do this the hard way, but I don't recommend it for a fresh E-rank."

The casual mention of their rank stung more than Hayami expected. E-rank. The lowest of the low. The Hunters who barely scraped by doing menial Gate maintenance work or mining low-level resources.

"Fine." Hayami untied their apron with more force than necessary. "Let's get this over with."

The Hunter Association's headquarters was a gleaming tower of glass and steel in the heart of Tokyo, all sharp angles and blue-tinted windows that reflected the city lights. Hayami had passed it countless times on the train, never imagining they'd be inside it, sitting in a sterile white room while a technician pressed sensors to their temples.

"Ability manifestation in three... two... one..."

Hayami felt the now-familiar tingle in their fingertips and let the electricity flow. Sparks crackled across their palm, casting flickering shadows on the walls.

The technician made a note on their clipboard. "Basic lightning manipulation. Output: 47 watts. Control: minimal. Classification: E-rank confirmed." They looked up with a sympathetic smile that somehow made everything worse. "You can stop now."

The assessment took two hours. Strength test—average. Speed test—slightly above average. Mana capacity test—disappointingly low. Combat aptitude test—they handed Hayami a practice sword and had them swing at a dummy. The blade felt awkward in their grip.

"No combat experience," the examiner noted. "Recommended for non-combat support roles or Gate mining operations."

By the time they finished, it was past three in the morning. Agent Tanaka met them in the lobby with a folder and a plastic card.

"Your official Hunter license." She handed over the card. It had Hayami's photo—when had they taken that?—and a large letter E in the corner. "You're now legally registered. Inside the folder, you'll find information about E-rank approved Gates, guild recruitment options, and safety guidelines."

Hayami stared at the card. It felt heavier than it should.

"What happens now?"

"That's up to you. Some E-ranks join guilds for the steady income. Others freelance. A few try to rank up through training, but..." Tanaka hesitated. "Most people stay at the rank they Awaken at. The System is pretty accurate about potential."

"So I'm stuck at E-rank forever." It wasn't a question.

"I didn't say that. Just... be realistic about your expectations." Tanaka's expression shifted to something almost pitying. "Go home. Get some rest. Welcome to the world of Hunters, Amamiya."

Hayami's apartment was a cramped studio in a building that had seen better decades. They dropped their bag by the door and collapsed onto their bed without bothering to turn on the lights. The blue screen flickered to life again, hovering in the darkness.

[REGISTRATION COMPLETE]

[SYSTEM FULLY ACTIVATED]

[DAILY QUEST FEATURE UNLOCKED]

Daily quest?

New text scrolled across the display:

[DAILY QUEST: FOUNDATION TRAINING]

Objective:

- Complete 100 push-ups (0/100)
- Complete 100 sit-ups (0/100)
- Complete 100 squats (0/100)
- Run 10 kilometers (0/10)

Time Limit: 24 hours

Rewards:

- +1 to all stats
- Random reward box

Penalty for Failure:

- -2 to all stats
- Luck decreased for 48 hours

Hayami sat up slowly, reading the quest three times to make sure they weren't hallucinating. One hundred push-ups? They could barely do twenty on a good day. And run ten kilometers? They hadn't run anywhere since high school gym class.

But the penalty...

They pulled up their status screen—another feature they'd discovered during the assessment:

[STATS]

- Strength: 12
- Agility: 14
- Vitality: 11
- Intelligence: 16
- Sense: 13

If they failed and lost two points from each stat, they'd be even weaker than they already were. And decreased luck? They didn't even want to know what that meant.

"This is insane," Hayami muttered. But the quest timer was already ticking down: 23:47:32.

They looked at the floor. Then at the quest window. Then back at the floor.

"Screw it."

Hayami got down on their hands and knees and started their first push-up. Their arms shook. Their form was probably terrible. But the counter ticked up: (1/100).

This was their life now. E-rank Hunter. Lightning manipulation that could barely power a light bulb. And apparently, a System that wanted them to train like they were preparing for the Olympics.

As they struggled through their eighth push-up, Hayami couldn't shake the feeling that this was only the beginning. The System wouldn't give them daily quests if it expected them to stay weak forever.

Would it?

(9/100)

Their arms gave out and they face-planted on the floor. Groaning, they pushed themselves back up.

(10/100)

Twenty-three hours and forty-five minutes to go.

This was going to be a long night.

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Hayami's arms felt like jelly by push-up number forty-three. Sweat dripped onto the worn carpet of their apartment, forming dark spots that would probably stain. They didn't care. The quest timer glowed mockingly in their peripheral vision: 21:13:08.

(44/100)

"This... is... bullshit," they gasped between reps. Their form had deteriorated into something that would make any personal trainer weep, but the System seemed to count it anyway.

(45/100)

The sky outside their window was starting to lighten—that sickly pre-dawn gray that made everything look washed out and depressing. Hayami had been at this for over two hours, taking breaks when their muscles literally refused to cooperate. The push-ups were torture. The sit-ups made their abs scream. And they hadn't even started the squats yet.

They were beginning to understand why most E-ranks stayed E-rank. Who had time for this?

(46/100)

Their phone buzzed from the nightstand. Hayami ignored it. Then it buzzed again. And again.

With a groan that came from somewhere deep in their soul, Hayami collapsed onto their back and grabbed the phone. Seven missed calls from the convenience store manager. Twelve text messages. The most recent one was in all caps:

WHERE ARE YOU??? YOUR SHIFT STARTED AN HOUR AGO!!!

"Shit." Hayami had completely forgotten. In the chaos of Awakening and registration and this insane quest, their Tuesday morning shift had slipped their mind entirely.

They pulled up the manager's number, then hesitated. What were they supposed to say? "Sorry, I Awakened as a Hunter and now I have to do a hundred push-ups or suffer mysterious penalties?" That would go over well.

The phone rang before they could decide.

"Amamiya." The manager's voice was ice. "Do you have any idea how many times I've called you?"

"I know, I'm sorry, something came up—"

"Something came up? We talked about this last month. One more absence and you're done."

Hayami closed their eyes. They needed this job. Their savings account had maybe ¥30,000 in it, and rent was due in two weeks. Hunter work didn't pay well at E-rank—most of the safe Gates had already been cleared repeatedly, leaving only scraps for low-level Hunters to scavenge.

"The Hunter Association came last night," Hayami said quietly. "I Awakened. They made me go in for registration. I just got home a few hours ago."

Silence on the other end. Then: "You're a Hunter now?"

"E-rank. Basically useless."

Another pause. When the manager spoke again, his tone had shifted—not warm, but no longer hostile. "I see. Well. That changes things. Listen, Amamiya, I can't hold your position. We need reliable people, and Hunters... even E-ranks have to do raids, right? Take quest assignments?"

"Yeah." The lie tasted bitter. Hayami had no intention of entering a Gate anytime soon. Not with their pathetic 47-watt lightning output.

"Then this isn't going to work. I'll process your final paycheck. You can pick it up Friday."

The line went dead.

Hayami stared at the phone for a long moment, then set it carefully on the floor beside them. Fired. They'd just been fired. Because they Awakened as the weakest possible rank of Hunter.

The quest timer flickered: 20:47:29.

"Fine," Hayami muttered. "FINE."

They got back into push-up position with renewed spite. If they were going to be unemployed and broke and stuck as an E-rank failure, they might as well complete this ridiculous quest. What else did they have to do?

(47/100)

By the time the sun was fully up, Hayami had somehow, miraculously, completed the push-ups and sit-ups. Their entire body was a symphony of pain. Muscles they didn't know existed were staging a revolt. But the quest log showed:

- Complete 100 push-ups (100/100) ✓
- Complete 100 sit-ups (100/100) ✓
- Complete 100 squats (0/100)

- Run 10 kilometers (0/10)

The squats were brutal but manageable compared to the push-ups. Hayami's legs trembled with each rep, but they pushed through, counting down rather than up. Ninety-nine felt better than one. It felt like progress.

(100/100) ✓

Three down. One to go.

Hayami looked at their running shoes—cheap things from a discount store, worn at the heels. Then at the quest timer: 16:22:14. Sixteen hours. They could do this.

They changed into the least disgusting clothes they could find, grabbed their phone and keys, and headed out. The morning air was crisp and cold, biting at their exposed skin. February in Tokyo didn't mess around.

The nearest park was about two kilometers away. Hayami had passed it hundreds of times but never actually been inside. It had a running path that looped around a small pond. They'd seen joggers there at all hours, faces serene or determined or blank with exhaustion.

Hayami started running.

Or rather, they started jogging. Slowly. Their legs, already exhausted from the squats, protested immediately. Their lungs burned. Their side cramped up before they'd even made it halfway around the first loop.

The System helpfully displayed their progress: (0.4/10 km)

"You've got to be kidding me," Hayami wheezed, stopping to clutch their side. An elderly woman power-walking past gave them a concerned look.

They kept going.

Somewhere around the third kilometer, something shifted. The pain was still there—constant, insistent—but Hayami found a rhythm. Left foot, right foot, breathe in, breathe out. The path blurred into a repetitive pattern of pavement and trees and the occasional other jogger.

(3.8/10 km)

Their mind wandered. What were they supposed to do now? No job. No prospects. E-rank Hunters were barely more employable than regular civilians—less so, actually, since people assumed Hunters would quit the moment something better came along.

Maybe they should try a Gate. The Association had given them a list of E-rank approved locations. Most were old Gates, barely active, used primarily for training or low-level resource gathering. Magic stones, mostly—the crystallized mana that dropped from defeated monsters. Even the smallest stones sold for a few thousand yen.

But Hayami had seen the news. Knew the statistics. Every year, hundreds of low-rank Hunters died in Gates, overwhelmed by monsters they thought they could handle or trapped when a Gate destabilized. E-ranks had the highest mortality rate.

(5.2/10 km)

Halfway there. Hayami's legs were numb now, moving on autopilot. Their clothes were soaked through with sweat despite the cold. Every breath felt like inhaling knives.

They thought about the System. The daily quest. Everyone said your rank was fixed at Awakening—that the System's initial assessment was absolute. But if that was true, why give daily quests? Why offer stat increases and rewards?

Unless the System knew something the Hunter Association didn't.

(7.9/10 km)

Hayami's vision was starting to blur at the edges. Their mouth tasted like copper. Just a little more. Just keep moving.

An old man on a bench called out as they passed: "Ganbare!" Keep going!

Hayami wanted to flip him off but didn't have the energy. They kept running.

(9.1/10 km)

(9.4/10 km)

(9.8/10 km)

Come on. Come on.

(10.0/10 km)

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!]

The notification flashed across their vision in brilliant gold letters. Hayami immediately collapsed onto the nearest patch of grass, gasping like a fish out of water. They didn't care that the grass was damp with morning dew or that people were staring. They'd done it. Somehow, impossibly, they'd completed the quest.

[CALCULATING REWARDS...]

[REWARDS DISTRIBUTED!]

[+1 to all stats]

[Random Reward Box obtained!]

[Would you like to open the Random Reward Box now?]

[YES] / [NO]

Hayami's finger hovered over the YES option, but they hesitated. What if it was something visible? Something that would materialize in the middle of the park? They didn't need more attention.

With effort, they dragged themselves upright and started the long walk home. Their legs felt like they belonged to someone else—someone who'd been hit by a truck.

Back in their apartment, door locked and curtains drawn, Hayami finally selected [YES].

A box materialized in front of them, hovering in the air. It was ornate, covered in swirling patterns that seemed to shift when Hayami looked directly at them. The lid opened on its own, and light spilled out.

[Random Reward Box Contents:]

Item Acquired: Basic Training Manual (Lightning Element)

A small book appeared in Hayami's hands, bound in blue leather with a lightning bolt embossed on the cover. It was warm to the touch, almost vibrating with contained energy.

They opened it to the first page:

"Lightning is not merely destruction—it is speed, precision, and transformation. To master the storm, you must first understand the spark."

"Exercise 1: Static Generation Form a sphere of contained lightning between your palms. Hold for 30 seconds. Repeat until the sphere remains stable without concentration."

Hayami looked at their hands. During the assessment, they'd barely managed sparks. A whole sphere? For thirty seconds?

But their stats had increased. They pulled up their status window:

[STATS]

- Strength: 13 (+1)
- Agility: 15 (+1)
- Vitality: 12 (+1)
- Intelligence: 17 (+1)

- Sense: 14 (+1)

The changes seemed small, but Hayami felt different. Less exhausted than they should be. Their thoughts clearer despite the lack of sleep.

They held out their hands, palms facing each other about a foot apart. Concentrated. The electricity came more easily this time, crackling across their fingertips. Slowly, carefully, they coaxed it into the space between their palms.

A spark. Then another. Then—

A tiny sphere of blue-white lightning formed, no bigger than a marble. It lasted maybe three seconds before dissipating.

But it had existed.

Hayami tried again. And again. By the sixth attempt, the sphere lasted five seconds. By the tenth, eight seconds.

They lost track of time, absorbed in the exercise. The training manual sat open beside them, and with each successful attempt, they swore they could feel something shifting inside them. Like a door unlocking. Like potential finally being acknowledged.

When they finally collapsed onto their bed, exhausted beyond measure, the quest window flickered to life again:

[DAILY QUEST: FOUNDATION TRAINING]

Objective:

- Complete 100 push-ups (0/100)
- Complete 100 sit-ups (0/100)
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Time Limit: 24 hours

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Penalty for Failure:

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- Luck decreased for 48 hours

The exact same quest. Again. Every day.

Hayami stared at it for a long moment, then started laughing—a slightly hysterical sound that echoed in their empty apartment. This was their life now. One hundred push-ups, one hundred sit-ups, one hundred squats, and a ten-kilometer run. Every single day.

The Hunter Association had written them off as a weak E-rank. Their manager had fired them. They had no money, no prospects, and abilities that barely qualified as superhuman.

But the System kept giving them quests. Kept offering rewards. Kept suggesting that maybe, just maybe, they could be more than what they'd been assessed as.

Hayami closed their eyes, feeling the ache in every muscle, the burn of electricity still tingling in their fingertips.

"Alright," they whispered to the empty room. "Let's see where this goes."

Outside their window, Tokyo moved on, indifferent to one more E-rank Hunter struggling in obscurity. But in that cramped studio apartment, something had begun—a spark that would one day become a storm.

Tomorrow, the training would start again.

And Hayami Amamiya would be ready.

[END OF CHAPTER 1]